

DIARY OF MRS. MINNA SPLETTSTOESSER

JOURNEY TO AMERICA

from October 8 to November 12, 1886

Journey to america

From Badeborn to Quedlinburg on the 8th of October. From there to Hamburg on the 9th of October. All train connections in the fourth class.

Sightseeing in Hamburg. Driving on the Alster (river). On the 11th of October departure from Hamburg. By boat transported to shipboard of the "Australia".

X October 11. Fore-noon, gloomy weather. After-noon, sunshine. Many ships in sight. Evening, very late on deck. Midday meal, barley soup. Supper, tea.

October 12. Fore-noon, rain. After-noon, gloomy weather. Many seasick. Evening, moonshine; a clear starlit sky. Spent much time on upper deck. Willy seasick. Morning, coffee. Midday meal, rice soup. Supper, tea. Dancing on deck. North Sea disturbed, some rocking.

October 13. Had coffee. Fine weather. The whole morning on deck. Many ships in sight. Sailingships and steamers in the canal. Waterway very calm, ship does not rock. I have yet to experience seasickness. Danced till noon on the quarterdeck. Midday meal, peasoup, potatoes and herring. We are making us some coffee every afternoon.

The "Australia" is a big emigrant-ship. There are more than a thousand people on it. the Salomon's are right at our side.

They are scrubbing twice a day. Steerage is being fumigated every other day. They have trumpets and harmonicas on the ship. Everybody is very cheerful.

Have seen land. England in sight. Supper, tea. Ate nothing. Moonshine. Very fine weather. For a long time on deck. (Proposal in cabin) Late. Ship started to rock. The first wave overboard.

October 14. The ocean is very disturbed. Storm and rain, high waves. Waves are coming overboard all the time. Did not drink coffee. Many seasick again. Everything disgusting.

Midday meal, rice soup, fruit dumplings. Tasted very good. Everybody throwing up. Dishes were flying back and forth. Cases and boxes too.

After noon, sunshine and storm. Had coffee. Doctor looked after Willy. Then on deck. I had not yet experienced seasickness and have thrown up today for the first time. Nobody did realize, that today is Sunday. We have not washed and combed. The children have kept on their nightshirts.

Many ships in sight. Evening, moonshine and a starry sky. Big pigfishes (dolphins) are flying.

October 15. The whole night quite a bit of rocking. Early in the morning sunshine. The coffee on ship tastes as bad as ever. Waves terribly high. The ship bends down constantly from one side to the other into the water. Around noon the doctor chased everybody onto deck. Storm and rain.

Food, barley soup, meat, potatoes. We did not take a bite. Dishes and everything were rolling all over the place. A chamberpot fell to pieces from the lavatory. Supper: ate nothing.

Little Fritz fell out of bed, under the beds, clear up to the wall and back again. Nobody could stay put. The stewards were busy till late tying everything down. I was up all night, holding little Fritz.

Tuesday, October 16. Sunshine and very high waves. Now we were up in the air, the next moment sinking down into the depths. Fishes were jumping. Still many seasick. In the steerage everything disgusts one.

Midday meal, beansoup, meat, potatoes. We took only potatoes and meat. For supper we brewed us some coffee and ate dry bread. At night a big disturbance again. In the evening moonshine. For a long time on deck.

Wednesday, October 17. Overcast skies and the water very restless. Prepared us some coffee. Little Fritz listless. Midday meal: peasoup, sauerkraut and potatoes. Did not taste too bad. On deck. Sun and wind. Coffee in the evening. Spent much time on deck, it was beautiful weather. Moonshine and a clear sky.

Thursday, October 18. Dismal weather. We cooked us some coffee. Bought rolls. Everybody had to go to the fore-deck. Midday meal: rice soup, plums and dumplings. It was tasteless.

In the afternoon a six year old girl died. At eleven at night overboard.

We were drinking coffee, sitting on the engine, till it started to rain.

Friday, October 19. Gloomy weather and rain. Made coffee. Midday meal: barley soup, meat and potatoes. Sunshine and wind. Checked the luggage. All got cards. Afternoon, prepared red sausage with vinegar and onions. Tasted very good.

Supper: nothing at all. The sea remains choppy.

Saturday, October 20. Made coffee. Horrible rocking during the night. Unfriendly weather.

Midday meal: beansoup, meat and potatoes. Then it clears up. On deck with the children till about dark. In the evening we ate red sausage, then danced on deck by lantern light till late.

Sunday, October 21. Had coffee. Stayed in bed very late. Then danced on deck again. Quite nice weather. Midday meal: rice soup, white cabbage and boiled potatoes. Tasted good. All the time the dancing on deck went on. It was such a lively Sunday for everyone.

A sailship in sight. Made coffee in the afternoon. Supper: herring and potatoes. Willy had an intolerable earache at night and wept all the time. Little Fritz has a bad cold and is coughing. Received a calendar and a pot from Mr. Brunschow. Dark evening.

Monday, October 22. Overcast, windy. Had coffee. Midday meal: peasoup, meat, sauerkraut and potatoes. Coffee in the afternoon. Spent the entire day in bed. The night had been horrible, high dashing of waves. Again everything chattered and rolled about pell-mell. Terrible rocking.

Tuesday, October 23. Dim weather and rocking of the ship. Had coffee. Have a very bad case of diarrhea. Have grown quite feeble. The sea is whipping up waves, high as houses. Midday meal: barley soup, dumplings and fruit. I ate nothing. Soup had to be filled into buckets, because dishes would roll all over the place. Children were flying from one end of the ship to the other. A boy fell from upstairs down the staircase. A little child was thrown out of bed and the back of its head caved in. Nobody was able to keep his food down, and to look at all that was dreadful. We did not leave our beds the entire day. We have gone past Newfoundland. Nobody was on deck. For supper they served oatgrits. Tasted very good. On deck it was as cold as in the harshest winter. A big whale has been behind the ship. At night the sea became calmer.

Wednesday, October 24. Had coffee. We buy ourselves rolls now every morning. They are very good, however the butter on board is not good. It still is very cold, but the sun shines and everybody is out on deck as if it were spring. Today we finally have washed and combed ourselves, that does not happen every day. Only, when the ship goes at a steady pace. Midday meal: beansoup, meat, potatoes. Then on deck with the children. The sea is not raising waves. Supper: plums and barley. Tasted dreadful. Then dancing on deck again.

Thursday, October 25. We had coffee with rolls. For breakfast red sausage with vinegar. The weather is terrible again. Torrents of rain, thick fog and a fearfully high sea. All the time waves overboard. One officer fell down the staircase, another flew into the gutter and dreadfully cold it is too. The wind is so cold.

Midday meal: rice soup, meat and potatoes. Everything was tumbling around again and there is much shrieking and laughing. I always lie in bed, while eating. It is a splendid mess. For supper grits again. Everybody was in bed, no one upstairs.

Friday, October 26. Coffee, ate rolls. Very foggy. For every length of ship the foghorn was blowing. Little Clara and I have packed all beds anew, put everything in order. Today the ship again goes steadily, at night too. Midday meal: barley soup, meat and white cabbage. For supper barley and plums. Two ships sighted. Danced on deck, then rain.

Saturday, October 27. This night the ship quiet. Had coffee, then knitting on deck. Four ships sighted. Always signaling with flags. Three times up and on their way again. Midday meal: beansoup, meat, sauerkraut and potatoes. For breakfast we ate pickled herring, four pieces. That too tasted very good. For supper grits again.

After that everybody on deck till late into the night and wanted to see land or wait for the ships pilot.

Many have been staying up out of joy to see land. The pilot arrived after eleven o'clock. At two o'clock in the night they called down to the steerage, that land has been sighted. Everybody jumped out of bed. The first thing we saw, was the Brooklyn Bridge. Those innumerable lights, something almost unbelievable. And then the ship turned around and we drove into port.

At five o'clock in the morning everybody was already washed and combed, as it became day and we saw New York. This view is so indescribable, such beauty no painter can paint.

Sunday, October 28. This colouring of the foliage, those villas down the slope; no, I cannot describe it. Those beautiful ships, much more beautiful than in Hamburg.

The ship docked till eight o'clock. Then the doctor from America came. All of us were checked for inoculation cards. That lasted till ten o'clock. At this time arrived two small steamers, to pick us up (the "Australia" is not going close to the pier). The departing were shouting "Hurrah", as long as they could see the ship. All, who had small luggage, were fetched first.

With the small steamers came the custom officials and people in boats with apples, sausage, bread and cake. In Hamburg they checked nothing.

In America no one bothers with scattered bags and small luggage. It is not being searched at all. Big cases are being opened. They take just one look and close them again. If one gives a tip, it is being checked at once. One can take with him whatever he wants, no duty to pay on anything. It is much easier, than one imagines.

Everybody has to go to Castle Garden. There they ask one for ones name and what one wants here. They do not demand documents at all. One could claim, whatever he pleases, it is all the same.

Later the gentlemen arrived and took us with them. Right after reaching the hotel, we went to dinner. That was a real treat once again after the disgusting fare on ship.

New York is a wondrously beautiful town. Hamburg is shit compared to it. The railway in the air, horsedrawn trolleys all through the night.

Afternoon, had coffee. Supper, tea, potato salad with roast, butter bread and cheese. Then I went for a stroll with the Salomon's. The first night I did not sleep at all.

Monday, October 29. Being awakened in the morning. Coffee with bread, butter, sausage and cheese. Midday meal, soup, roast and plenty more to go with it. Food always in abundance.

It rained for the second day. All the time acquaintances from the ship were coming to visit with us again. The Herzberg's are staying in New York. Very nice people. Mr. Rothenberg with his cousin, still a young girl, from the ship. The ship's doctor, officers and everyone, the Salomon's too, are lodging together in Schoenfelds' Hotel. The service here is very good. Everything, but everything, much nicer than in Hamburg. I am being preciously entertained in New York. (Only constantly getting lost). However, here are already mosquitoes in the beds. I have slept better the second night. I dream only always so horribly about murdering.

X Tuesday, October 30. A beautiful day. Today we went to have a look at New York once more. Coffee with rolls, bread, butter and cheese. The evening before - supper, X roast, fried potatoes. Before that cole slaw, potatoes in their jackets, butter, cheese and tea. One can really refresh oneself.

X Had a bout with cholera. Have become quite frail. Fetched medicine from the pharmacy shop.

X Midday meal: roast, soup and different tidbits. Little Clara came in the afternoon. Afterwards I was lying down. Have seen nothing of New York.

X Supper: tea, dumplings, roast, bread and boiled potatoes, butter and cheese. Ill in the evening. Have not slept a single night.

Wednesday, October 31. Coffee with rolls. After it I drank hot punch with cloves and nutmeg. Felt a little better. Then to Castle Garden, to get the luggage. Fifteen cents for transportation of case. Thirty-five cents for a rope, to go around basket, iron broken. One dollar for delivery of case and basket onto board. Thirty-five cents for accompaniment from board.

Midday meal still at Schoenfelds' Hotel, soup, carrots, roast, boiled potatoes, red cole slaw, bread butter.

Afterwards to the office to get tickets, then on board of the American ship. Is three times as large as "Australia", much nicer furnished. Smaller rooms, like third class railway compartments.

Supper on shipboard, tea, roast, potatoes. We sleep in a heated cabin. Breakfast, coffee with little cakes for the children. For everybody coffee, white bread, roast, potatoes. After that coffee and little cakes for Fritzchen, then beer. Tasted very good.

In the night there was a storm and it became very cold. The American ship does not rock half as much as the "Australia".

In the banquet hall a glass chandelier, three banquet tables with benches of red velvet. Everything so dainty, as I have never seen before. People so friendly, showing one around everywhere.

As we departed from New York, it was magnificent, the Brooklyn Bridge, those ferries and men-of-war, sailships, boats. The view of the land, the woods, the villas gleaming in the setting sun.

Red, however, is the colour of the Americans. Red dresses, stockings, hats, feathers, everything red. Looks very beautiful. The wheels and engines red on ship.

The cook prepared us gruel for dinner. Here we are much better off than on the German ship. At Schoenfelds' we paid three dollars.

Thursday, November 1. Midday meal, soup, meat, potatoes, ship crackers. The steward fed me and the children better food in his room. Rice soup, carrots, turnips, boiled potatoes, raisin dumplings, butter and white bread. Thus we have dined splendidly.

Supper, coffee, rice with wine, orange jam and American cake. Afterwards with company from "Australia" for a long time on deck, because the weather was so magnificent. The sea is always less calm at night.

Friday, November 2. Had coffee and baker's ware with the children in the berth, then fried fish, potato dumplings with fish, meat deliciously fried, rolls with butter. I wanted to give the steward money, but he said no money (nix geld).

Midday meal, carrot soup, fish, potatoes and ship crackers. Did not sleep this night. During the day the weather marvelous, sunshine.

Name of ship "San Marco". Everybody here gets a plate, mug, spoon, fork and knife. Very nice. The general dishes are washed by the steward.

For their midday meal the people got fish with potatoes, carrot soup with pepper. Supper, tea, potatoes and meat. I ate with the children in the berth again. The old man means so well, yet unfortunately I understand him too little.

Saturday, November 3. Had coffee. We wash and comb on this ship every day. Our chamber is being heated. But now that is not necessary anymore. The sun is already shining so hot, as she does at home in the summer. Every day it becomes warmer. Every day ships sighted. Today I was sweating already while just standing still on deck. I wanted to mend; however, it was impossible for me.

For the second time coffee, cake, fish, cutlet. Midday meal, rice with wine, coffee with assorted baker's ware and sugar-bonbons. Everyone jokes with the children and enjoys it. Supper, cake, afterwards they dance. People are much more decent and easygoing than on the "Australia".

Sunday, November 4. Slept well. Dressed up. Coffee with cake, fish, sausage and baked apples. Tasted very good. The weather is hot and windy.

We ate at midday, soup, potatoes, roast. Supper, tea, potatoes, ham.

Monday, November 5. It rained quite a lot at night. All the time along the coast of Florida. I had a fearful headache.

During the day beautiful view. The different hues of the water, the woods, the buildings, the lighthouses, that is wonderously beautiful.

Breakfast, coffee, cake, different tidbits. Midday meal, soup, potatoes, roast, cake and beer. Rain in the afternoon. Very hot in the berth. Willy and little Fritz are staying all the time with the "cake uncle". Dancing everyday. Supper, potatoes, meat, bread, tea. A little windy on deck, otherwise wonderful. At night again a horrible ache.

Tuesday, November 6. Willy in the morning at the uncle's place, coffee and cake, afterwards once more coffee for the three of us. Nearly anytime one gets here a warm meal. One has only to ask for it.

The children have got very much American sugarthings from a little girl, who travels in a cabin. In the afternoon coffee, sausage, fish, rice and the usual. Weather delightful. Ache.

Wednesday, November 7. Coffee and sausage, cutlets and rolls. In the afternoon coffee and cake. Weather delightful. Danced everyday to the harmonica.

Thursday, November 8. Rolls. Did not eat much. Very fine weather. Often on deck. At four o'clock in the afternoon, land sighted. What happiness! We are coming closer and closer to the destination we are longing for. How beautiful the coast in the setting sun, later moonshine. The numerous ships, lighthouses. In the evening, half past nine, Galveston. Mr. M. has conducted a tour with us. At first the whole ship, then Galveston. Till twelve o'clock we were walking around. Then awake on ship for a long time.

Many have left the ship entirely as early as in the evening. There was no food for anybody next morning, only I and the children were served coffee with bread and butter.

Afterwards I remained still on board till lunch, coffee, dumplings, cake. Then I was taken by Mr. M. to the telegraph office. Telegram to Fritz. Then in town. He has

arranged everything. He is a German. Later we left for Houston at half past three. Arrived in Houston in the dark. +

Friday, November 9. These are strange towns with splendid houses, wooden houses, huts. Beautiful roads, mud roads, wilderness. Beautiful shops, everything mixed wildly together. How very American. Thus the people too.

We rode the horse-trolley to Lamont House, that is a big hotel. The innkeeper, Mr. Seez, hails from Zerbst. I was so bold and never afraid. All of them marvelled about me. They did not believe at all, that I have come from Germany just now. Fritz had already been in Houston for four days. He expected us to travel by train. Now he had gone back, but had written my name into the questbook. I had a very nice room. I could not sleep at night because of the heat.

Saturday, November 10. Beautiful weather in Houston. Breakfast, then for a walk with the children. Afterwards, we had our midday meal, then sleep.

Later a stroll with a German woman. Visited other hotels, had plenty of beer. Returned at half past four. Boarded right away the hotelcab to drive to the station, in order to call for papa. And he really was on the train. How happy Fritz was, to see us. Together we drove back to the hotel. We could not come to an end in telling all to each other. He inquired for everything in particular.

He found Willy, as he had imagined he would be. However, he had no notion at all of little Fritz, what he would be like. He did not know him at all.

Fritz still is exactly as he was. As he stepped out of the car, I recognized him on the spot. It was dark, when we returned. We had supper. Fritz already is quite well-known in Houston.

Sunday, November 11. At eight o'clock in the morning we left Houston. It rained heavily.

At nine o'clock this evening we arrived in Moscow. Lodged at Bright Hotel in Moscow.

X Monday, November 12. Travelled by wagon from Moscow to Kurth Station. Arrived at ten o'clock in the new home. +

INVENTORY

A. Total received: 120 Marks

1 wardrobe	8
1 sideboard	10
1 chest of drawers	6
1 table	6
6 chairs	6
3 buckets	2 $\frac{1}{2}$
2 pots with lids	
1 cookie sheet	1 $\frac{1}{2}$

B. Items

silk dress
mirror, lamp
furware
wintercoat
sewing machine plates 18 thalers
china coffee mill
sofa 60 Marks Eduard

C.

1. dresses &	2. skirts &
1 black	3 white linen
1 with squares	1 white wool
1 brown	1 white fustian
1 with squares	1 grey wool
1 brown	1 lined
1 stripped	2 linen children's suits
1 lustre (half wool)	1 dark suit
3 calico	2 dresses, little Fritz
1 cambric	1 pair boots
2 printed	1 pair linen shoes
1 linen	1 pair woolen shoes
2 bed sheets	1 pair little linen shoes

D. Assorted items

2 beds, 1 tablecloth	1 wagonblanket, 2 wool shawls
9 featherbed covers, 11 bedsheets	1 skirt, 2 bundels, 2 diapers
2 dozen shirts, 7 pieces	14 colored aprons, 11 aprons
3 pants, 14 handkerchiefs	2 pants, 1 filled pillow with children's wear
6 tablecloths, 6 napkins	1 box with collars
2 bedjackets, 1 sideboard cloth	1 box needlework, thread, etc.
4 sofadoilies, 2 corner doilies	1 box with neckties and bows
23 pairs white stockings	1 box with letters
5 pairs cotton	$\frac{1}{2}$ dozen forkknives
3 pairs wool, 10 pairs children stockings	
1 bag filled, 14 children shirts	
16 big & 6 small handkerchiefs	
11 small neckcloths	

E. Paper

album
briefcase
picturebook
Technologist
texas
reader
3 technology
2 readers
1 album
1 Bible
1 notes
1 game (Lotto)
1 hymnal

F. Miscellaneous foods (probably travel provisions)

lemons, evaporated milk, chocolate, rum, sugar, wine, burnt coffee,
pork tallow, material, hot punch, lemonade extract

G. List of Birthdays

Father	June 14
Mother	December 19
Dorothee	March 31
Christoph	July 18
Johanne	November 26
Eduard	October 25
Friedrich	August
Luiſe	January 25
Auguste	March 17
Minna	September 19
Gustav	December 5
Malie	February 18

Papa	January 26
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Willy	February 26
Fritz	May 10
Minne	September 7
Clara Voelkelt	September 21